Change Request Management: Expense Tracker Project

(Day 13)

Study Summary: Scope Creep and Change Control

Scope creep is the slow, unapproved growth of a project's scope; a formal Change Request (CR) stops it by making every change visible, assessed and approved before any work starts.

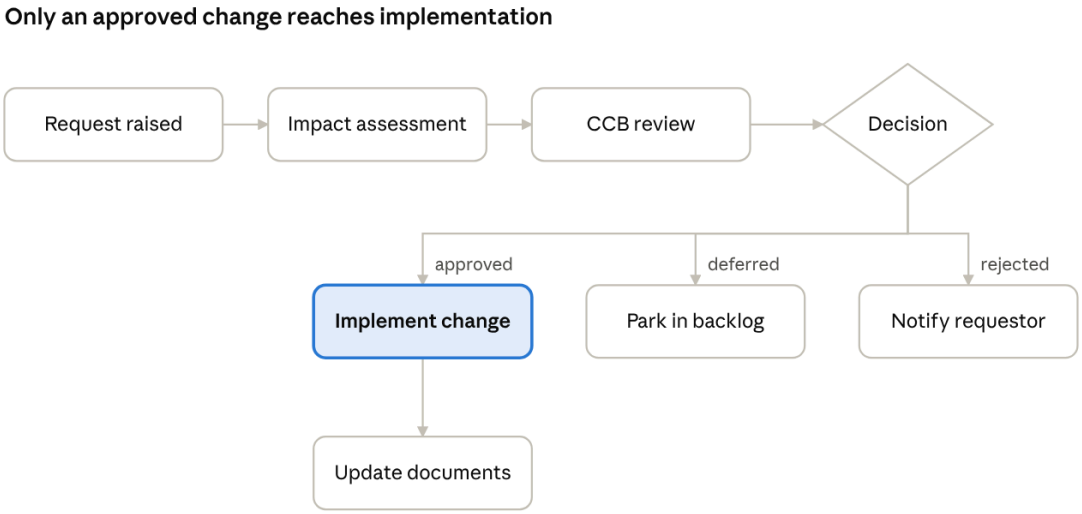
How it starts. A stakeholder asks for "one small thing" in a hallway chat or an email, such as an extra field on the Expense Tracker's export, and the team agrees informally to keep the relationship smooth. Nothing is written down, nobody checks the effort, and the work being done no longer matches the baseline plan.

Why it damages the project. Every small yes adds unplanned work, which the team absorbs through overtime or by cutting testing. Timelines slip, budgets overrun and capacity for planned work shrinks. No single request looks big, so the damage only becomes visible when a deadline is missed.

How a CR prevents it. A CR turns "can you just add..." into a written proposal with costed impact on scope, time, cost and risk. A named group decides, the baselines are updated, and everyone sees what the change costs. Small changes are not blocked; they are priced and decided on purpose.

The Change Control Process

1. **Request raised.** Anyone raises the change on the CR form; the PM logs it with a CR ID.
2. **Impact assessment.** The PM and team estimate the effect on time, cost, scope and risk, and list options.
3. **Review by the Change Control Board (CCB).** The board (sponsor, product owner, PM, tech lead) reviews the impact and the PM's recommendation.
4. **Decision.** The CCB records Approved, Rejected or Deferred, with the reason.
5. **Implementation.** An approved change is scheduled and delivered like any other work.
6. **Documentation update.** Scope, schedule and budget baselines, the risk register and the CR log are updated, and the requestor is told the outcome.



change control flow · 6 steps, 3 outcomes

An approved request is implemented and documented; a deferred one waits in the backlog, and a rejected one closes with the requestor informed.

Change Request Form Template

Use one form per change; the PM completes the impact fields before the CCB meets, and the CCB completes the decision and sign-off.

Field	What to enter
CR ID	Unique sequential ID, e.g. CR-001
Project	Project name
Date	Date the request was raised
Requestor	Name and role of the person asking for the change
Description of Change	What exactly changes, in plain words: what is added, removed or altered, and what stays the same
Business Justification	Why the change is needed and what happens if it is not made
Impact on Scope	Requirements, deliverables and documents added, changed or removed; what is explicitly excluded

Field	What to enter
Impact on Timeline	Effect on milestones and the delivery date, in working days, with old and new dates
Impact on Cost	Effort hours and rate, other costs, % of budget, how it is funded, revised budget
Impact on Risk	New or changed risks, their rating and mitigation; overall risk level (Low, Medium, High)
PM Recommendation	Approve, reject or defer, with conditions and the options considered
Decision	Approved, Rejected or Deferred, with date, decision-maker and reason
Sign-off	Name or role, decision and date for the sponsor, CCB chair and PM; baselines updated (yes/no)

Completed Change Requests

The three CRs below are fictional scenarios on the Expense Tracker project. Each is written against the same assumed baseline, as if raised on its own; all figures are illustrative.

Baseline item	Assumption
Scope	Add, edit and delete expenses; categories; monthly summary reports; budget alerts; CSV export; mobile-friendly web app
Schedule	12 weeks, 2026-08-31 to 2026-11-20 (code freeze 2026-11-06, UAT 2026-11-09 to 2026-11-20)
Budget	₹25,00,000 (₹25 lakh), including ₹1,25,000 contingency
Team and rate	1 PM, 2 developers, 1 QA, 1 part-time designer; blended rate ₹3,250 per hour
Governance	CCB meets Thursdays: sponsor, product owner (chair), PM, tech lead

CR-001: Add a Currency Converter Feature

A mid-project feature request that the CCB approved with conditions, because the cost exceeds the contingency and the date moves one week.

Field	Details
CR ID	CR-001
Project	Expense Tracker
Date	2026-10-05 (week 6 of 12)
Requestor	Product Owner
Description of Change	Add a currency converter. Users pick a foreign currency when logging an expense; the app converts it to their base currency (INR) using a daily exchange rate from a third-party rate service and shows converted totals in reports.
Business Justification	Pilot users travelling between three regional offices log expenses in AED, EUR and USD and convert by hand today, which causes entry errors and duplicated effort. The feature is expected to decide adoption beyond the pilot.
Impact on Scope	Adds three requirements: a currency field on expense entry, daily rate retrieval and storage, and converted totals in reports. Changes the data model, report logic, test plan and user guide. Excludes historical rate back-fill and multi-currency budgets.
Impact on Timeline	+5 working days. Delivery moves from 2026-11-20 to 2026-11-27. About 96 effort hours of build and test do not fit around the current critical path.
Impact on Cost	+₹3,37,000 (13.5% of budget): 96 hours at ₹3,250 = ₹3,12,000, plus ₹25,000 first-year rate-service subscription. The ₹1,25,000 contingency covers part of it; ₹2,12,000 needs new funding. Revised budget: ₹27,12,000, contingency fully used.
Impact on Risk	Overall: Medium. New third-party dependency (outage or rate limits): cache the last known rate and show its date. Regression risk in report totals: add test cases. QA squeeze: absorbed by the extra week. No contingency left for later changes.
PM Recommendation	Approve with conditions: (1) sponsor funds the ₹2,12,000; (2) delivery date moves to 2026-11-27; (3) scope limited to the three requirements above. Options considered: defer to

Field	Details
	Release 2 (no impact now, feature arrives later); manual rate-entry field only (24 hours, about ₹78,000, no delay, but no automatic rates).
Decision	Approved with conditions, CCB meeting 2026-10-08. Full feature accepted on the PM's conditions. Baselines updated: delivery 2026-11-27, budget ₹27,12,000.
Sign-off	Project Sponsor: approved 2026-10-08. CCB Chair (Product Owner): approved 2026-10-08. Project Manager: logged and baselines updated 2026-10-08.

CR-002: Move the Delivery Date by 2 Weeks

A schedule-only change: no new features, but a cost for keeping the project team on hold during the longer UAT window.

Field	Details
CR ID	CR-002
Project	Expense Tracker
Date	2026-10-12 (week 7 of 12)
Requestor	Client Finance Director (Project Sponsor)
Description of Change	Move final delivery two weeks later, from 2026-11-20 to 2026-12-04. Development still ends at the planned code freeze on 2026-11-06; only the UAT window moves, from 2026-11-09 to 2026-11-20, to 2026-11-23 to 2026-12-04.
Business Justification	The client finance team is committed to the quarter-end close and an audit until 2026-11-20 and cannot staff UAT. Testing during the close would give rushed, incomplete sign-off.
Impact on Scope	None. Requirements are unchanged and the scope freeze stays in force: no features are added during the longer window.
Impact on Timeline	+10 working days to delivery. Code freeze stays 2026-11-06; UAT runs 2026-11-23 to 2026-12-04; go-live 2026-12-04.

Field	Details
Impact on Cost	+₹2,31,000 (9.2% of budget): PM, QA and developer standby for two weeks, 68 hours at ₹3,250 = ₹2,21,000, plus ₹10,000 for two extra weeks of staging hosting. The ₹1,25,000 contingency covers part of it; ₹1,06,000 needs new funding. Revised budget: ₹26,06,000.
Impact on Risk	Overall: Low to Medium. Developers may be reassigned during the gap and slow defect fixes: name one on-call developer for 8 hours a week. Requirements drift: keep the scope freeze. Go-live nears the year-end holidays: no further extension without a new CR.
PM Recommendation	Approve with conditions: (1) scope freeze stays in force; (2) Finance commits named UAT staff for 2026-11-23 to 2026-12-04 in writing; (3) sponsor funds the ₹1,06,000. Option considered and not recommended: keep 2026-11-20 and run UAT with a reduced team, which risks an incomplete sign-off.
Decision	Approved with conditions, CCB meeting 2026-10-15. Baselines updated: delivery 2026-12-04, budget ₹26,06,000.
Sign-off	Project Sponsor: approved 2026-10-15. CCB Chair (Product Owner): approved 2026-10-15. Project Manager: logged and baselines updated 2026-10-15.

CR-003: Reduce the Budget by 20%

A budget cut that only works if scope shrinks with it: the CCB approved it on condition that two features move to Release 2.

Field	Details
CR ID	CR-003
Project	Expense Tracker
Date	2026-10-14 (week 7 of 12)
Requestor	Head of Finance, for the company cost-saving programme
Description of Change	Reduce the total budget by 20%, from ₹25,00,000 to ₹20,00,000 (-₹5,00,000), effective immediately. About

Field	Details
	₹13,00,000 is already spent or committed, so the cut falls on the remaining ₹12,00,000: 42% of it.
Business Justification	A company-wide cost-saving programme requires every active project to release 20% of its budget this quarter.
Impact on Scope	To live within the remaining ₹7,00,000, two items move to Release 2: budget alerts (60 hours, ₹1,95,000) and charted reports (40 hours, ₹1,30,000). The table-based monthly summary, expense entry, categories and CSV export stay.
Impact on Timeline	No change: delivery stays 2026-11-20, provided the two features are removed from the plan.
Impact on Cost	-₹5,00,000 (-20%): contingency released ₹1,25,000; budget alerts deferred ₹1,95,000; charted reports deferred ₹1,30,000; shared staging environment instead of a dedicated one ₹50,000. Revised budget: ₹20,00,000 with zero contingency.
Impact on Risk	Overall: High. With no contingency, any estimation error or defect rework overruns the budget. Shared staging may delay testing. Pilot users asked for budget alerts and may be disappointed. Mitigation: weekly cost tracking, escalation if the forecast exceeds ₹20,00,000 by more than ₹60,000 (3%), and both features logged in the Release 2 backlog with estimates.
PM Recommendation	Approve only with the descoping above. Not recommended: taking the 20% cut with scope unchanged, which would mean cutting QA effort and raising defect risk.
Decision	Approved with conditions, CCB meeting 2026-10-15: budget alerts and charted reports formally deferred to Release 2; scope and budget baselines updated to ₹20,00,000.
Sign-off	Project Sponsor: approved 2026-10-15. CCB Chair (Product Owner): approved 2026-10-15. Project Manager: logged and baselines updated 2026-10-15.

Waterfall vs Agile: Handling Scope Change

In Waterfall, scope is fixed up front and every change goes through a formal Change Request; in Agile, change is expected, so the backlog absorbs it and a formal CR is rarely needed.

Waterfall signs off scope, schedule and budget as a baseline, so any change threatens that baseline. It needs an impact assessment, a CCB decision and an updated plan, exactly as in CR-001 to CR-003 above.

In Agile, the Product Owner can add, remove or reorder backlog items at any time. A new item is estimated and competes for a place in a future sprint; a change inside a running sprint waits for the next planning session or swaps with work of equal size. Time and budget stay fixed while scope flexes, so adding something means something else moves out. A formal CR is kept only for changes to overall budget, deadline or contract, which is why CR-002 and CR-003 would still be raised in an Agile project.

In short, Waterfall controls change to protect the plan; Agile controls it by prioritisation to protect delivered value.